

Final Reflective Essay

As Earth burns, floods and warms in real time, the billionaires have a plan. Buy a ticket to Mars. Founder of SpaceX, Elon Musk has long championed the idea that becoming a “multi-planetary species” is the only way to safeguard humanity against extinction events (The Economic Times, 2025). Before they sell us the dream of a backup planet, we must ask ourselves: Why are we abandoning our only home?

All this sounds like a high-budget sci-fi film until reality hits. We have all the proof we need to show that this will not work. NASA already told us that terraforming Mars is not feasible with our current technology. The planet lacks enough accessible carbon dioxide to generate an Earth-like greenhouse effect and even vaporizing all polar ice would only raise atmospheric pressure to 4-5% of Earth’s, far too thin for liquid water stability (NASA, 2022). Even our robotic attempts struggle, with only about 40% of all Mars landing attempts succeeding (McCarthy, 2018). Yet, here they are, discussing a “Plan B” that is entirely theoretical and functionally impossible for the foreseeable future.

Worse still, the very space projects are inflicting further harm on our fragile Earth right now. A single SpaceX Starship launch releases about 76,000 metric tons of CO₂-equivalent emissions and pumps black carbon into the upper atmosphere, where it could double with more launches (BBC, 2022). These launches also release massive amounts of water vapor—estimated at 6 kilotons annually into the stratosphere across global rocket activity, while launch sites like Starbase in Texas have repeatedly dumped untreated wastewater into local waters (NBC News, 2024). Rather than escaping our problems, we are piling on new

threats to Earth's atmosphere and ecosystems as we speak, accelerating the crisis we claim to flee.

We need a serious reality check and a shift in our collective willpower. Prioritizing Earth isn't just about policy; it's about acknowledging that we have a debt to the only planet that actually keeps us alive. Why are we pouring billions into a space-age fantasy when we can address the crisis at its source? We still have time to pivot, yet building an Earth-like Mars—if even possible—would take anywhere from thousands to hundreds of thousands of years (PBS, n.d.). Are we seriously going to stand by and watch our home suffer while waiting on a miracle that will not happen in our lifetime? We have already proven that we can lower carbon emissions and build more resilient cities—throwing those hard-won victories away for a Martian mirage would be such a waste of our previous efforts. What's even worse is how this whole 'escape plan' feels. It is an elitist game. If the future of humanity is a golden ticket to another world, what happens to the billions of people who do not have a seat at the table? This is not a strategy for saving humanity; it is a lifeboat for the one percent.

With that being said, it does not mean space programs should be shut down entirely. Yet, we need to stop pretending that exploration is a substitute for responsibility. Satellites and space technology are brilliant, essential tools which help us track climate patterns, predict natural disasters and manage our resources more carefully. Exploration should be an extension of our care, not a way to turn our backs on our problems. Mars might be a great place to let our imaginations run wild, but Earth is the only place we actually have to live.

If we commit to this path, the benefits reach everyone, not just a privileged few. When governments prioritize clean energy, our cities become safer; when businesses innovate for

sustainability, our economy becomes more durable. For us, keep supporting climate-resilient policies and refuse to buy into the marketing of "Plan B" planets. We can stop leaders from chasing interplanetary delusions and force them to use those massive budgets to build the clean-energy systems and flood-resilient infrastructure that will actually save lives. Every cent spent on repairing our own planet is a direct investment in the people living here today, rather than a gamble on an impossible tomorrow.

Reflecting on Mars colonization, I kept returning to a simple question: why are we building life elsewhere when life here is already under such immense pressure? We do not prove human greatness by fleeing our problems, we prove it by facing them. Earth is not a backup plan and it deserves to be saved first.

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Video Essay

Link: https://youtu.be/6-kB0e9iY_Y?si=K5yVfQ0_fXFnCdrR

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